UNIVERSITY OF WOLVERHAMPTON

MSc Computer Science Project Handbook

School of Engineering, Computing and Mathematical Sciences

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Introduction

This handbook is for online students embarking on their dissertation project. This is an opportunity for you to study a topic in the relevant field and develop your research, report writing and presentation skills. These projects can also include the development of artefacts, providing you with the opportunity to develop your practical skills.

The projects will be supervised by a member of academic staff, who will also serve as first marker for the project. A second member of staff will be allocated to the project as the second assessor. The projects will run for a total of sixteen weeks. The project supervisor will communicate regularly with you to set tasks and discuss various aspects of the work.

There will be two summative assessments:

1. Project proposal (15%) - due at the end of Week 8
2. Dissertation (75%) - due at the end of Week 16

One aim of project work is that you should enjoy an opportunity to study independently and hence should be allowed a certain amount of leeway in how they do the project. This is best done by agreement between students and supervisors and so although these notes contain certain rules, it is important that both parties feel able to negotiate between themselves an appropriate course of action in most instances. A key aim is that you should be given the opportunity to show your strengths. This project module is very different from your previous module as it will require independent work on open-ended questions, where there might be no definitive answer or solution.

Allocation of Supervisors

You will be assigned a project supervisor, with instructions to contact the allocated supervisor and commence the dissertation journey during Week 1 of the module.

It is very difficult to change supervisors once the module has started and this will be done in exceptional cases only, where possible.

Once allocated to a supervisor, it is your responsibility to contact your supervisor to discuss issues and report on your progress, and to ensure you understand what is required in terms of submission and assessment. You could contact your supervisor using a Teams message or email. You can also discuss communication with your supervisor to identify any preferences.

Supervisor Contact

You should have regular contact with your supervisor. Communication with your supervisor is

likely to be frequent at the beginning, as you will probably need more guidance and support when you are preparing/refining the project plan and ethical approval documentation.

At the start of each week, you should contact your supervisor and give a brief account of your progress.

The progress update should address the following points:

- tasks undertaken since your last progress update.
- tasks you plan to work on before your next progress update.
- any issues you have encountered or are at risk of encountering.

Your supervisor will review your progress and plans and reply in a timely manner. It is your responsibility to provide these weekly progress updates and engage in regular communication with your supervisor.

Ethical Approval

Your project must undergo a consideration of the ethical implications in line with section 3.4 of the Handbook for Ethical Review and Approval (2023-2025) All studies which include any of the factors listed for consideration must undergo full ethical approval by the Computing and Mathematical Sciences Ethics Subject Panel. As this is a time-consuming process, you should seek to ensure your project does not require committee approval.

As part of the process, you should complete the Ethical Considerations form (Appendix B) in discussion with your supervisor.

Draft submissions

There are a series of formative portals in your classroom. You must use these portals to submit drafts of the relevant sections of your report for formative feedback. Written feedback on your draft sections will only be provided through these portals – you will receive feedback once for each section.

Although there are suggested due dates, you can submit your work to the portals on a date agreed with your supervisor. It is strongly advised that you email your supervisor and alert them to your submission, so they can provide feedback.

The portals and suggested due dates are as follows:

1. Draft Proposal (end of Week 2)
2. Draft Introduction and Literature Review (end of Week 8)

3. Draft Design (end of Week 10)
4. Draft Implementation, testing and results (end of Week 14)
5. Draft report (end of Week 15)*

*The Draft report portal is an opportunity for your supervisor to provide feedback on the overall layout and structure of your report, rather than the content per se.

Submission of Summative Assessments

There are two summative assessments to submit for this module.

1. Project proposal (15%) - Due end of Week 8.
2. Dissertation (85%) - Due end of Week 16.

Assessments should be submitted **electronically via the module canvas page** by the submission deadline (see canvas assignment task). The electronic versions should be in Word, pdf, or some other common format. **Electronically scanned copies of a wholly handwritten report are not permitted.** You should keep a copy of the report for your own records.

The submission will be checked for plagiarism using the standard University software. If any plagiarism is suspected, the standard University procedures on plagiarism will be followed. Information on what constitutes plagiarism can be found on the University website:

https://www.wlv.ac.uk/current-students/conduct-and-appeals/academic-misconduct/

If you are unable to submit your work, you should refer to the appropriate processes for extensions and extenuating circumstances in the Student Handbook. The final project report should include a summary (typically, in the introductory section) describing the scope of the work and the main results, indicating the main sources used. Pages and sections should be numbered for easy reference and the title page should contain student name, student number, module code and title, title of project, supervisor, and the date of submission. The report should include a contents page and a full reference list, indicating all the books, articles or websites used. Your report should be 7,000 words (+/-10%) (excluding bibliography and appendices).

If a result, piece of code etc., is taken from a source, there must be an indication of the source, and whether it has been significantly expanded or adapted. Apart from short statements, you should not copy directly from sources, and everything must be expressed in your own words, except where explicitly stated. Students whose work is too closely based on their sources will have marks deducted. Guidelines on **Harvard referencing** can be found on the University Learning Centre's webpage:

http://www.wlv.ac.uk/lib/skills for learning/referencing.aspx

http://www.wlv.ac.uk/lib/skills_for_learning/referencing/harvard_referencing.aspx

Appendix C contains formatting guidelines for the final report.

Assessment Marking

Your project is marked by your supervisor, and independently by a second marker. Each marker will independently complete the appropriate sections of the rubrics in SpeedGrader. In the case of a disagreement over the mark, a third marker will independently mark the project to agree the grade.

Your final grade and feedback will be available in Canvas three weeks after submission.

The marking descriptors in Appendix A demonstrate the broad expectations for each grade band. Only the grades listed can be awarded. There are marking rubrics available in your dissertation classroom which set out the specific marking criteria – you should familiarise yourself with the rubrics and marking descriptors at the start of your project.

Responsibilities

Supervisor

- To discuss proposals with students in Weeks 1-2 of module and set initial tasks.
- To assess whether a study requires ethical approval and if so, guide the student through the necessary process.
- Provide regular communication with students for discussing progress and setting additional tasks. Provide advice and support within the limits of the allocated time.
- To report any concerns regarding student work (such as absences or low participation) to the online computer science team.
- To provide formative feedback to students on the quality of their work once per draft section.
- To assess the final report, liaise with the second marker, and provide feedback.

Second marker

- To assess the final report, liaise with the supervisor and agree a final mark.

Student

- Provide regular progress updates to supervisor.
- Work independently and take responsibility for progressing the project.
- Work efficiently towards deadlines.
- Develop independent work free of plagiarism.
- Engage with Canvas regularly, i.e., course material, announcements, etc.
- Respond in a timely manner to communications from the supervisor.

Timeline

Time	Action
Week 1	Milestone 0 - Project Commencement & Supervisor Discussion
Week 2	Milestone 1 – Project Proposal
⋮	⋮
Week 4	Milestone 2 – Abstract & Introduction
⋮	⋮
Week 8	Milestone 3 – Literature Review
⋮	⋮
Week 10	Milestone 4 – Design
⋮	⋮
Week 12	Milestone 5 – Implementation
⋮	⋮
Week 14	Milestone 6 – Testing & Results, Experimentation & Results
⋮	⋮
Week 16	Milestone 7 – Final Adjustments and Submission

Further Support

You can contact the online computer science team with any feedback, comments or concerns by emailing computing.online@wlv.ac.uk

Appendix A – Marking Descriptors

DISTINCTION	COMMENDATION	PASS	FAIL
Outstanding: **95** Excellent **85**, Very good: **75, 77**	Good: **62, 65, 68**	Clear Pass: **52, 55, 58**	Marginal Fail: **48, 45, 42** Clear Fail: **38, 35, 32, 25** Little or Nothing of Merit: **10, 0**
The assessed work will demonstrate:	The assessed work will demonstrate:	The assessed work will demonstrate:	Work of insufficient quality to achieve a Pass standard. 'Fail' grade work may suffer from some or all the following issues:
• An in-depth and systematic conceptual understanding of the topic • All the elements of the question set have been addressed • Independent thought, rather than relying simply on the ideas of others, perhaps as contained in the prescribed reading of the module • Reading beyond that specified by the module author, reflecting a broad literature review, where appropriate • Reading with a critical understanding • Ability to evaluate theoretical concepts and draw appropriate conclusions • Where appropriate, reflective and critical application/integration of theoretical concepts to empirical and practical issues • An ability to analyse and synthesise information presenting material using structured, logical discussion and critical argument • Clarity and conciseness, well-constructed and articulate writing that will be presented to a high standard using academic/professional language • Harvard Referencing	• A good conceptual understanding of the topic • That all the key elements of the question set will have been addressed • Some evidence of independent thought rather than relying simply on the ideas of others, perhaps as contained in the prescribed reading of the module • Evidence of reading beyond that specified by the module guide. • Evidence of a good grasp of prescribed literature • An ability to evaluate theoretical concepts and draw appropriate conclusions • An ability to apply theoretical concepts to empirical and practical issues • Clarity and conciseness, well-constructed and articulate writing that will be presented to a high standard using academic/ professional language • Accurate and consistent use of the appropriate referencing system • Clear and concise written expression • Reference complete and consistent with Harvard guidelines	• Satisfactory conceptual understanding of the topic • That some of the key elements of the question set will have been addressed. • Some evidence of independent thought rather than relying simply on the ideas of others, perhaps as contained in the prescribed reading of the module • Some familiarity with, and satisfactory understanding of, prescribed literature • Some evidence of application of theoretical concepts to empirical and practical issues, and integrating theory and practice • PASS grade work may suffer from some or all the following issues: • Inclusion of some materials not directly relevant to the set question • Providing an incomplete answer to the set question • Weaknesses in structure or in clarity • Some errors in referencing in terms of the use of the appropriate referencing system and/or consistency	• Achievement of very few/none of the module learning outcomes • Completely fails to address the question set (e.g., student has written at length about the wrong topic) • Token or no attempt to integrate theory and practice • Little or no understanding of theoretical and empirical considerations • Little or no reference to appropriate literature • Little or no evidence that the student has grasped key ideas • Unduly descriptive and/or lacks analysis • Badly presented • References largely incomplete and not consistent with Harvard guidelines • An assessment offence has been committed • Is submitted in contravention of University submission regulations

Appendix B - Ethical Considerations Form

MCS COMMITTEE ON THE ETHICS OF RESEARCH

Registration of a Research Project

This form must be completed by the Researcher(s) and, in cases where the applicant is a student, in collaboration with the project supervisor to determine if the project requires approval by the FSE Research Ethics Committee.

YOUR DETAILS

First Name: Surname:
Student Number: Supervisor:
Course:
Project Title:

YOUR PROJECT

State in no more than 100 words the problem(s) your project is aiming to address.

Will your project involve:

(a) Human participants
(b) Data about humans
(c) Sensitive information

YES / NO
If yes, please complete Page 2 of this form. Otherwise, please sign here, and pass it on to your supervisor.
Student Signature:
Date:

Human participants	Yes	No
Does the proposal involve vulnerable participants (for example, are they under 18 years of age, do they have a disability or are mentally unable to consent)?	☐	☐
Privacy		
Does the proposal involve processing of genetic information or personal data (e.g., health, sexual lifestyle, ethnicity, political opinion, religious or philosophical conviction)	☐	☐
Does the proposal involve tracking the location or observation of people without their knowledge?	☐	☐
Research on Animals		
Does the proposal involve research with animals?	☐	☐
Research Involving Developing Countries		
Is any of the research involving one of the Least Developed Countries?	☐	☐
Dual Use		
Does the research have direct military application?	☐	☐
Does the research have the potential for terrorist abuse?	☐	☐

Appendix C – Project Report Formatting Guidelines

At master's level, referencing is taken seriously because you are expected to demonstrate to a high degree that your work is based on a full knowledge and evaluation of the work of others in the field.

You must use the **Harvard Referencing style** in your Dissertation.

Here are some additional formatting guidelines to follow:

Formatting

The project report should be produced on A4 with a left margin of 30mm, right margin of 20mm, top margin of 25mm and bottom margin of 30mm.

No more than 1.5 line-spacing, using 12pt Times New Roman or Palatino.

Title page should appear on a single unnumbered page.

Appendices should be started on separate sheets at the back of the report and preceded by a page blank except for the heading "Appendix A" one third of the way down the page

Word Count

The word count for the report is dependent on the type of project, one that involves a large element of practical work can attract less words than one that focuses on analysis and design. Maximum word count should be 7,000 words (+/-10%)

Numbering

Page numbering should start with Chapter 1. Title page, acknowledgements and contents pages should not be numbered. Pages should be numbered consecutively through the main text, including diagrams, etc. Page numbers should be shown centrally at the bottom of the page in the bottom margin.

Tables and figures should be numbered separately but consecutively within chapters e.g., Table 3.1, Table 3.2, Figure 3.1, etc.

Pagination of appendices should be continuous but distinct from the main text, e.g., A1, A2, A3,, B1, B2, B3.

Headings

The text should be organised as a sequence of numbered chapters. There should be no chapters or headings at the bottom of a page. New chapters should start on a new page. Within each chapter the material should be broken down into sub-sections with their own sub-heading. A hierarchical system of numbering chapters, sub-sections and paragraphs should be used. It is not advisable to extend past three levels of hierarchy e.g.

1.

1.4

1.4.2

Headings and titles should be printed in bold characters. Underlining/underscoring should not be used for headings and should be used in the rest of the body of the text with considerable restraint.

Paragraphs

The start of paragraphs should not be indented differently from the remainder of the paragraph.

Quotations

Direct quotations from external sources should be indented inside both left and right margins. Quotation marks ("...") should be placed around them and the reference to the quotation given. Shorter quotations, less than three lines, can be embedded in the text.

Graphics

You will be expected to use the appropriate software packages for preparing diagrams, tables, pictures, and other graphics.